Predicting Median Housing Values in California:
A Statistical and Machine Learning Analysis

Technical Report

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Executive Summary

This report documents the end-to-end statistical analysis of the California Housing dataset (1990 U.S. Census, 20,640 block-group records), covering data cleaning, exploratory data analysis (EDA), predictive model development, and validation. After cleaning, 18,575 records remained for analysis. Two candidate models were compared to predict median house value: a multiple linear regression baseline and a random forest regressor. Using 5-fold cross-validation and a held-out 20% test set, we selected the random forest regressor as the final model, achieving a test RMSE of approximately $44,715 and $R^2 = 0.796$, compared with $58,464 RMSE and $R^2 = 0.652$ for linear regression. Median household income was the most influential predictor in the random forest (by feature and permutation importance) and the largest numeric coefficient in the linear model. Residual diagnostics revealed right-skewed, mildly heteroscedastic residuals (Shapiro-Wilk $p < 0.001$), a limitation discussed in Sections 7.2 and 8. Additional robustness checks (Sections 7.4–7.6) show that the forest outperforms linear regression in every cross-validation fold, that errors are larger for high-value districts, and that accuracy for geographically new regions is about 35% worse than the random-split estimate.

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1. Introduction

Housing affordability and valuation are central questions in applied statistics and urban economics. This project analyzes the California Housing dataset, derived from the 1990 U.S. Census, to build a model that predicts the median house value of a census block group from geographic, demographic, and housing-stock characteristics. The objective is twofold: (1) to produce a statistically sound, well-validated predictive model, and (2) to communicate the reasoning behind model selection using appropriate statistical diagnostics rather than accuracy metrics alone.

The project follows a standard applied statistics workflow: data cleaning and preparation, exploratory data analysis, model development and comparison, and validation of the final model's statistical assumptions.

2. Data Description

The raw dataset contains 20,640 observations across 10 variables: longitude, latitude, housing median age, total rooms, total bedrooms, population, households, median income, median house value (target), and ocean proximity (categorical: <1H OCEAN, INLAND, NEAR OCEAN, NEAR BAY, ISLAND). Each row represents a census block group rather than an individual household.

Variable	Description
Median house value	Target variable: median value of owner-occupied homes (USD)
Median income	Median household income (tens of thousands USD)
Housing median age	Median age of houses in the block group (years)
total rooms / total bedrooms	Aggregate room and bedroom counts for the block group
population / households	Aggregate population and household counts
ocean proximity	Categorical proximity to the ocean

3. Data Cleaning and Preparation

Cleaning followed a reproducible pipeline (src/data_prep.py) applying the following steps in order:

- Duplicate removal: exact duplicate rows were dropped (0 found).
- Invalid record removal: rows with non-positive housing median age, total rooms, households, or median house value were removed, along with rows where total bedrooms logically exceeded total rooms.
- Top-coded target handling: median house value is capped at $500,001 in the source data, producing an artificial spike at that value. We removed the 965 top-coded records; the model's scope is therefore restricted to block groups with median values below $500,001.
- Missing-value imputation: total bedrooms had 207 missing values (1.0% of records). These were imputed using the median total bedrooms within the same ocean proximity group, a context-aware alternative to a single global median. Imputed values were capped at that row's total rooms to preserve logical consistency.
- Feature engineering: three ratio features were derived — rooms per household, bedrooms per room, and population per household — which are more directly informative than the raw aggregate counts.
- Outlier removal: the 1.5×IQR rule was applied to rooms per household and population per household, removing 1,100 extreme records (e.g., block groups with implausibly high rooms-per-

household ratios). This step was applied to the full dataset before the train/test split, so the test set is also filtered; Section 7.6 quantifies the effect.

After cleaning, 18,575 of the original 20,640 records (90.0%) remained for analysis.

4. Exploratory Data Analysis

4.1 Distribution of the Target Variable

The distribution of median house value is right-skewed (skewness = 0.78), with a mean of $193,935 and median of $176,400. This is consistent with typical income and price distributions, where a majority of block groups cluster at moderate values while a smaller number of higher-value areas extend the right tail.

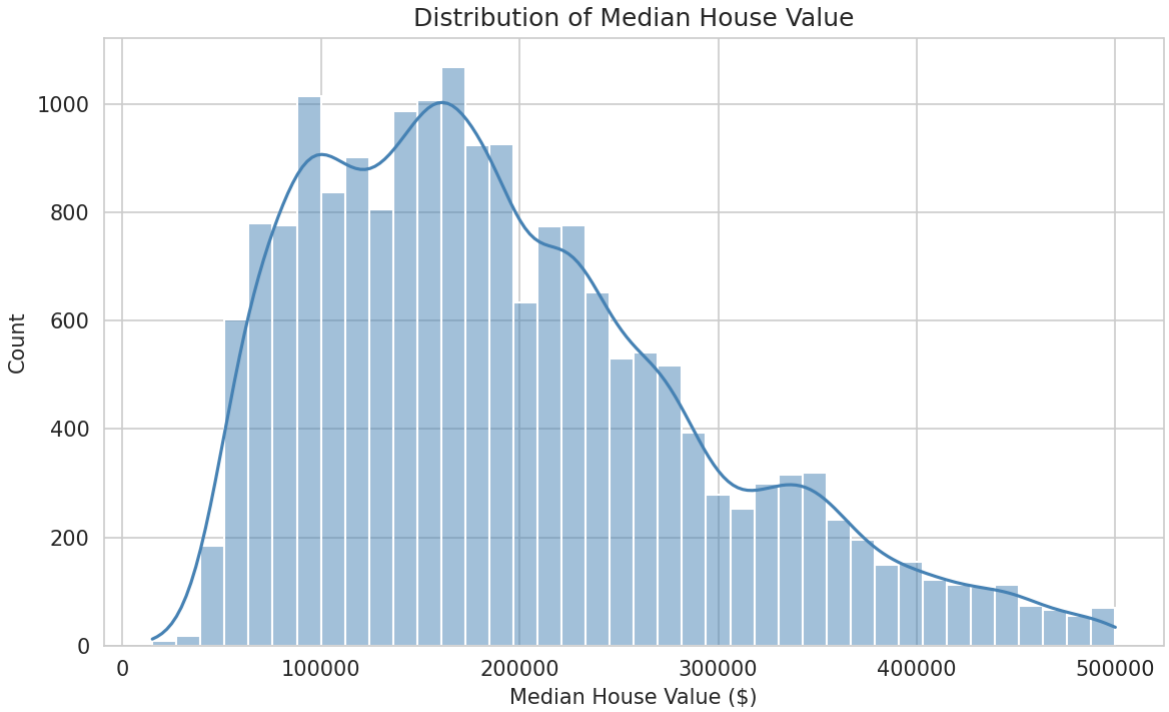


Figure 1. Distribution of median house value after cleaning.

4.2 Correlation Structure

Median income shows the strongest linear association with the target (r = 0.64), consistent with economic expectations. Rooms per household and bedrooms per room are strongly negatively correlated (r = -0.80), reflecting that block groups with more rooms per household tend to have proportionally fewer bedrooms per room (larger, non-bedroom living space).

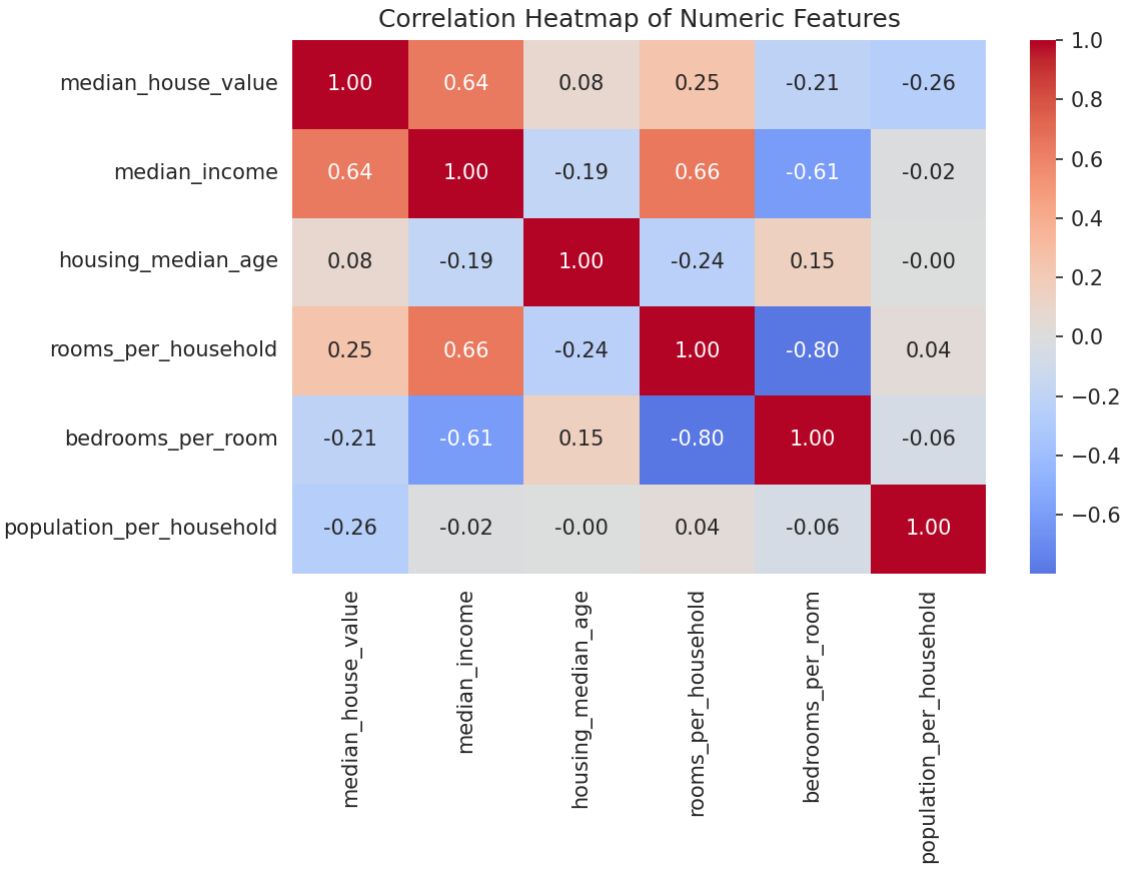


Figure 2. Correlation heatmap of numeric features.

4.3 Income vs. House Value



Figure 3. Median income vs. median house value. The positive association is clear, with increasing spread (heteroscedasticity) at higher income levels.

Figure 3 shows a clear positive, roughly linear relationship between income and house value ($r = 0.64$). The vertical spread of points widens as income rises, so equally wealthy neighborhoods can have quite different home values; this is the source of the mild heteroscedasticity examined in Section 7.2.

4.4 Geographic Distribution

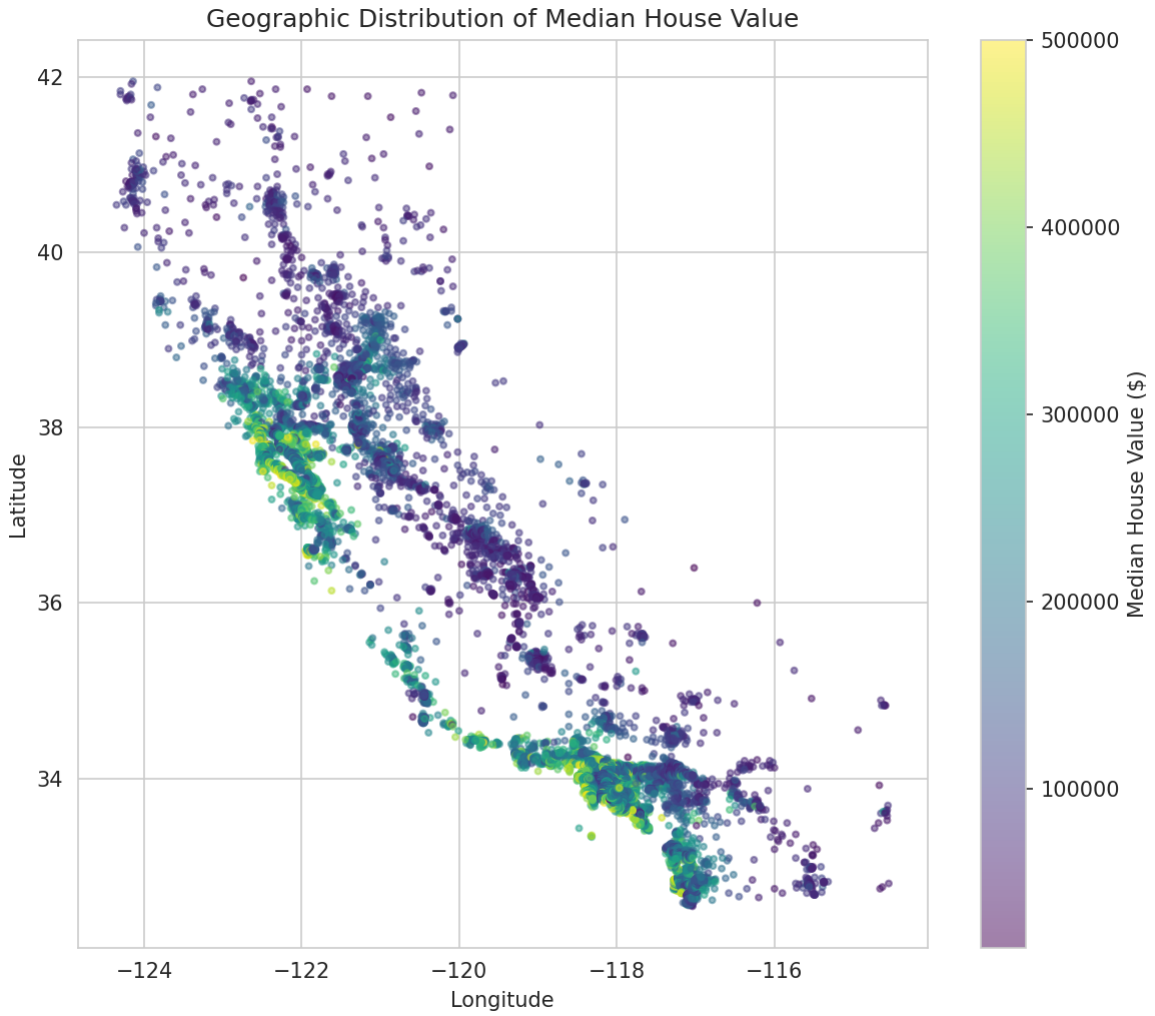


Figure 4. Geographic distribution of median house value across California. Coastal areas, particularly near the Bay Area and Los Angeles, show visibly higher values.

Figure 4 maps values by coordinates. The highest values cluster along the coast, particularly around the San Francisco Bay Area and the Los Angeles–San Diego corridor, while the interior Central Valley is cheaper. This is why longitude and latitude carry predictive information beyond income alone (Section 6.1).

4.5 House Value by Ocean Proximity

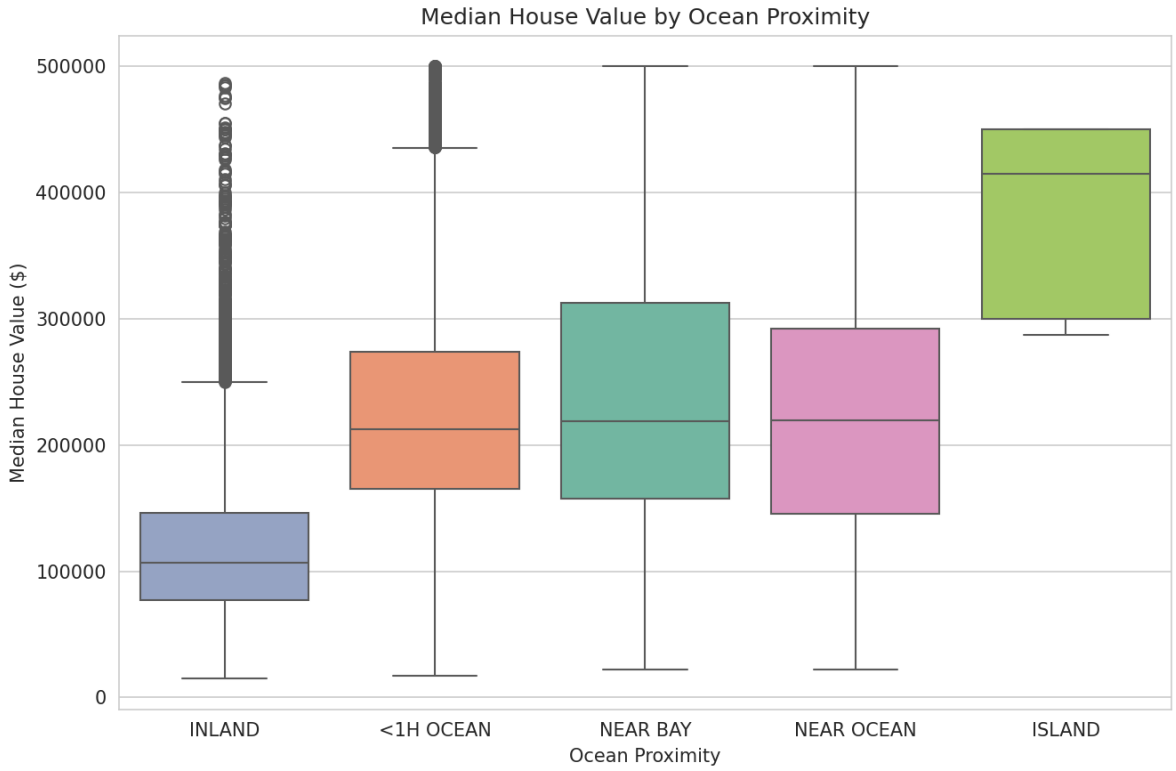


Figure 5. Median house value by ocean proximity category. INLAND block groups show systematically and substantially lower values, later confirmed as the second most important predictor in the random forest model.

Mean house value is $121,901 for INLAND block groups (n = 6,063), compared with $226,818 for <1H OCEAN, $228,678 for NEAR OCEAN, and $236,579 for NEAR BAY. The ISLAND category contains only 5 records (mean $380,440), too few to estimate reliably; see Section 7.3.

5. Model Selection and Methodology

The cleaned data were split into training (80%, n = 14,860) and test (20%, n = 3,715) sets using a fixed random seed for reproducibility. All numeric features were median-imputed (safeguarding against any residual missingness) and standardized; the categorical ocean proximity feature was one-hot encoded. Both steps were encapsulated in a scikit-learn column Transformer so that imputation medians, scaling parameters, and category lists are learned from the training data only. The cleaning steps in Section 3 (outlier removal and top-code exclusion), however, were applied to the full dataset before the split; their effect is quantified in Section 7.6.

Two models were trained and compared:

- Linear Regression: an ordinary least squares baseline, included to establish an interpretable reference point and test whether a linear, additive model adequately captures the relationship between predictors and price.
- Random Forest Regressor (Breiman, 2001): an ensemble of 150 regression trees (max depth 18, min samples leaf = 3), selected as a candidate capable of capturing non-linear relationships and interaction effects (e.g., the value of income may depend on geographic location) without requiring explicit interaction terms. Tree depth and count were chosen by hand to keep the saved model small and were not tuned by search. A comparison with a 300-tree unconstrained forest (src/hyperparam_check.py) gave nearly identical test accuracy (RMSE $44,520, R^2 0.798 versus $44,715 and 0.796) but a saved model about eight times larger (about 402 MB versus 52 MB uncompressed).

Model comparison used 5-fold cross-validation on the training set, scored by root mean squared error (RMSE), followed by a final, single evaluation of each fitted model on the held-out test set to obtain an estimate of performance on data not used for fitting. The model with the lower mean cross-validated RMSE was selected as final and re-evaluated on the test set for reporting.

6. Model Analysis: Results

Model	**CV RMSE (mean ± SD)**	**Test RMSE**	**Test MAE**	**Test R^2**
Linear Regression	$57,478 ± $1,208	$58,464	$43,137	0.652
Random Forest (final)	**$45,204 ± $1,391**	**$44,715**	**$29,899**	**0.796**

Note: ± is the sample standard deviation (n − 1) of RMSE across the five cross-validation folds.

The random forest reduced test RMSE by about 24% relative to linear regression and improved R^2 from 0.652 to 0.796, indicating it explains substantially more of the variance in median house value. Training and test performance differ by model. Linear regression scores almost identically on both (R^2 0.653 vs. 0.652; RMSE $57,433 vs. $58,464), so it is not overfit but is limited by its linear form. The random forest fits the training data much more closely (R^2 0.935, RMSE $24,832) than the test data (R^2 0.796, RMSE $44,715), as random forests typically do. What matters for generalization is that held-out error is stable: cross-validated and test RMSE differ by less than 2% for both models, and the forest remains clearly better on data it has not seen.

6.1 Feature Importance (Random Forest)

Feature	Importance
median income	0.429
ocean proximity: INLAND	0.181
Population per household	0.111
longitude	0.077
latitude	0.069

Median income alone accounts for roughly 43% of the random forest's total feature importance, consistent with its strong marginal correlation identified in the EDA. Notably, longitude and latitude together contribute meaningfully (about 15% combined), confirming that geographic location carries predictive information beyond what is captured by ocean proximity alone — consistent with the visible coastal-value gradient in Figure 4.

Permutation importance on the test set, which measures how much RMSE worsens when one feature is shuffled, gives a similar ranking: median_income ($42,430), latitude ($20,576), ocean_proximity ($19,897), longitude ($19,357), and population_per_household ($17,601) matter most, while housing_median_age adds $6,562 and every other feature less than $1,200. Because impurity-based importances can be inflated for correlated features, this check supports the conclusion that income and location drive the predictions.

Linear-model coefficients should be read with care because several predictors are strongly collinear. Variance inflation factors are 92.9 for households, 65.9 for total_bedrooms, 26.1 for population, and 23.9 for total_rooms, with latitude and longitude near 10. Predictions are not affected, but individual coefficients for these variables are unstable. The most reliable coefficient is median_income: a one-standard-deviation increase is associated with about +$60,845 in predicted value, holding other variables fixed. The ISLAND coefficient (+$122,803) rests on only 5 records, none of which fall in the test set, and should not be interpreted.

7. Model Analysis: Statistical Validity and Model Selection Discussion

7.1 Why Random Forest Was Selected

Model selection was based on cross-validated RMSE rather than a single train/test split, reducing the risk that the comparison reflects one particular partition of the data (an application of the sampling-variability principle: a single point estimate of performance carries sampling error, while averaging over 5 folds gives a more stable estimate of true generalization error). The random forest's lower cross-validated RMSE (by about $12,274, or 21%) is consistent across folds; the fold-to-fold RMSE standard deviation is $1,391 for the forest and $1,208 for linear regression.

Because both models were evaluated on the same five folds, the comparison can be made pairwise. The forest had lower RMSE than linear regression in all five folds, by between $11,632 and $13,155 (mean difference $12,274, SD $627; 95% confidence interval $11,496 to $13,053). With only five folds, this interval is approximate, since folds share training data, but the margin is far larger than the fold-to-fold variation.

For the final model, a bootstrap over the test set (resampling the 3,715 predictions) gives 95% confidence intervals of $42,753–$46,809 for RMSE, 0.778–0.812 for R^2, and $28,821–$31,019 for MAE. These intervals describe uncertainty from the finite test sample only; they do not capture the data-cleaning and spatial-generalization effects examined in Sections 7.5 and 7.6.

The magnitude of improvement also matches the underlying data structure observed in EDA: the relationship between predictors (especially geographic coordinates and ocean proximity interacting with income) and house value is not purely linear or additive. Random forests can model such interactions and non-linearities without explicit specification, which is a plausible statistical explanation for its improved fit over ordinary least squares.

7.2 Residual Diagnostics

For a regression model to support valid inference (beyond point prediction), residuals should be approximately normally distributed with constant variance (homoscedasticity). These assumptions were assessed for the final model on the test set:

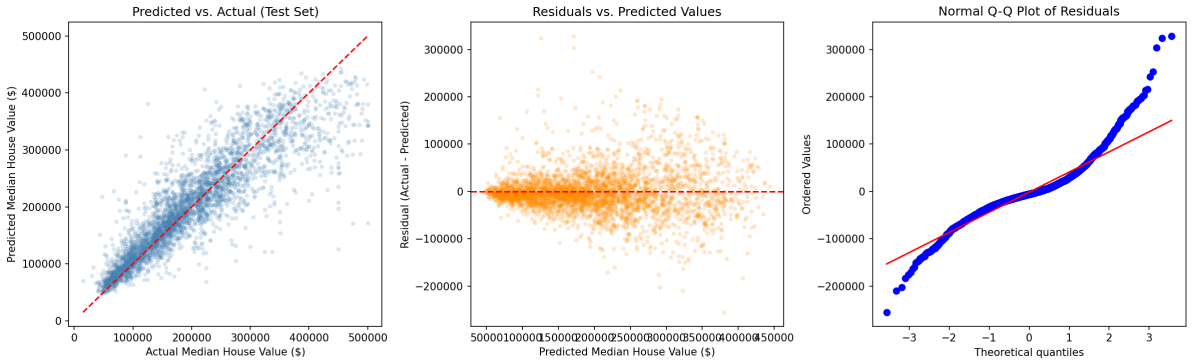


Figure 6. Predicted vs. actual values (left), residuals vs. predicted values (center), and a normal Q-Q plot of residuals (right) for the final random forest model on the test set.

- Predicted vs. actual (left panel): points cluster around the 45° reference line, confirming the model tracks the target reasonably well across most of its range, with somewhat more scatter at higher home values.

- Residuals vs. predicted (center panel): residual spread increases modestly at higher predicted values, indicating mild heteroscedasticity — the model is less precise for higher-value block groups than for lower-value ones.
- Normal Q-Q plot (right panel): residuals deviate from the reference line in both tails, most visibly in the upper tail, indicating the residual distribution is right-skewed with heavier tails than a normal distribution.

A Shapiro-Wilk test (Shapiro & Wilk, 1965) on all 3,715 test-set residuals formally rejected the null hypothesis of normality ($W = 0.908$, $p < 0.001$). Given the very large sample size, even small departures from normality can produce statistically significant results; the Q-Q plot provides more informative, practically interpretable evidence of the skew's magnitude.

7.3 Implication for Model Use

The residual non-normality does not invalidate the model's point predictions — random forests make no distributional assumption about residuals during training, unlike ordinary least squares. However, it does mean that naive symmetric prediction intervals (e.g., prediction ± 1.96 × RMSE) would understate uncertainty for high-value block groups and should not be used for formal interval estimation without adjustment (e.g., via quantile regression forests or bootstrap-based asymmetric intervals).

7.4 Where the Model Is Less Accurate

Errors are not uniform. Grouped by actual house value, the model over-predicts cheap districts and under-predicts expensive ones, a typical regression-to-the-mean pattern. Error is largest for the most expensive districts, which also explains the right-skewed residuals in Section 7.2.

Actual value	n	RMSE	MAE	Mean pred − actual
≤ $100k	702	$28,077	$17,926	+$15,287
$100–200k	1,484	$34,988	$23,896	+$13,994
$200–300k	967	$42,086	$31,622	−$325
$300–400k	407	$56,191	$42,753	−$25,724
$400–500k	155	$115,286	$97,102	−$96,630

By region, errors are lowest for INLAND block groups (RMSE $34,322) and highest for NEAR OCEAN ($56,145) and NEAR BAY ($52,813), where prices are higher and more variable. The ISLAND category has no test records.

Region	n	RMSE	MAE	Mean pred − actual
<1H OCEAN	1,622	$45,384	$31,858	+$3,142
INLAND	1,195	$34,322	$21,200	+$1,903
NEAR BAY	417	$52,813	$37,184	+$1,968
NEAR OCEAN	481	$56,145	$38,592	−$5,101

7.5 Generalization to New Regions

The random train/test split lets the model see neighboring block groups during training, which flatters accuracy when predicting for a place it has never seen. To test this, block groups were clustered geographically with k-means and whole clusters were held out in cross-validation. Spatial-block RMSE was $59,977 ± $7,806, compared with $44,347 ± $1,393 for random folds under the same procedure, about 35% worse. The headline figures in Section 6 should therefore be read as accuracy for areas similar to those in the training data, not for new regions.

7.6 Sensitivity to Cleaning Choices

Cleaning (Section 3) was applied before the split, so we re-ran the comparison under alternative choices. The random forest beats linear regression in every variant; only the absolute level of error changes.

Variant	RF RMSE	RF R^2	Linear RMSE	Linear R^2
Team pipeline	$44,715	0.796	$58,464	0.652
No IQR outlier removal	$46,363	0.784	$62,105	0.613
Split first, test keeps outliers	$46,389	0.784	$62,177	0.612
Split first, test filtered	$46,332	0.785	$59,521	0.645
Keep $500,001 rows, all test rows	$49,501	0.819	$64,901	0.688
Keep $500,001 rows, scored on < $500k	$44,990	n/a	$57,385	n/a

Outlier filtering of the test set improves reported RMSE by about $1,600 (3.6%) for the forest, so the headline figure is somewhat optimistic for unfiltered data. Keeping the capped $500,001 rows raises R^2 only because the target range widens; on the rows below the cap, accuracy is essentially unchanged.

8. Limitations

- Top-coding exclusion: removing records at the $500,001 cap means the model does not extrapolate reliably to California's highest-value housing markets.
- Data age: the dataset reflects 1990 Census conditions; relationships between income, location, and housing value may have shifted substantially in the intervening decades, so the model should not be used for current market prediction without re-fitting on recent data.
- Ecological-level data: each record aggregates an entire census block group, not an individual household; inferences should not be applied to individual homes (an instance of the ecological fallacy).
- Mild heteroscedasticity and larger errors for expensive districts: prediction uncertainty is not constant across the price range, as shown in Section 7.2, and should be communicated accordingly rather than as a single fixed margin of error.
- Interpretability trade-off: the random forest, while more accurate, is less directly interpretable than linear regression; feature importances describe overall influence but not the sign or functional form of each effect.
- Cleaning scope: IQR outlier removal narrows the population the model applies to and flatters test metrics by roughly $1,600 (3.6%) relative to unfiltered data (Section 7.6).

- Spatial generalization: a random split overstates accuracy for new regions; spatial-block cross-validation gives RMSE about 35% higher (Section 7.5).
- Sparse category: ISLAND has only 5 records, so its effect cannot be estimated reliably.
- Limited tuning: hyperparameters were set by hand, and only two model families were compared; gradient boosting or tuned models could perform better.

9. Conclusion and Recommendations

This analysis cleaned, explored, and modeled the California Housing dataset, comparing a linear regression baseline against a random forest regressor using cross-validated statistical evaluation rather than a single accuracy figure. We selected the random forest as the final model because it consistently reduced RMSE and improved R^2 in cross-validation, supported by EDA showing that income and location interact in ways a purely linear model cannot capture. Residual diagnostics confirmed reasonable point-prediction accuracy while identifying right-skewed, mildly heteroscedastic residuals that should inform how prediction uncertainty is communicated. Robustness checks show the forest's advantage holds across folds and alternative cleaning choices, but accuracy is lower for high-value districts and geographically new regions, so the reported figures should be read as estimates for areas like the training data.

Recommendations

- Use the random forest for point predictions of median house value in areas similar to the training data, and report them with an error of about ±$45,000 (RMSE); expect larger errors, about $56,000 to $115,000, for districts valued above $300,000 (Section 7.4).
- Do not apply the model to new regions without retraining or re-validating it on local data; spatial cross-validation raised RMSE by about 35% (Section 7.5).
- Do not interpret individual coefficients of the linear model for rooms, bedrooms, population, or households, because they are strongly collinear (Section 6.1); if interpretation is needed, use regularized regression or principal components.
- Before any production use, update the data (the source is the 1990 Census) and consider keeping the capped $500,001 districts with an appropriate censored-data method, since removing them narrows the model's scope (Section 8).
- Next steps for accuracy: tune hyperparameters with nested cross-validation, compare gradient boosting, and use quantile regression forests or bootstrap methods for asymmetric prediction intervals (Section 7.3).

10. References

Pace, R. K., & Barry, R. (1997). Sparse spatial autoregressions. Statistics & Probability Letters, 33(3), 291–297. (Original source of the California Housing dataset.)

Breiman, L. (2001). Random forests. Machine Learning, 45(1), 5–32.

Géron, A. (2019). Hands-On Machine Learning with Scikit-Learn, Keras, and TensorFlow (2nd ed.). O'Reilly Media. (Dataset distribution used in this project.)

Pedregosa, F., et al. (2011). Scikit-learn: Machine Learning in Python. Journal of Machine Learning Research, 12, 2825–2830.

Shapiro, S. S., & Wilk, M. B. (1965). An analysis of variance test for normality (complete samples). Biometrika, 52(3–4), 591–611.

11. Appendix: Code Output

This appendix reproduces the output of the technical notebook, Running-full-pipeline.ipynb (included in the project repository), which runs the project scripts in order: src/data_prep.py, src/eda.py, src/model.py, src/rigor.py, src/sensitivity.py, and src/hyperparam_check.py. Output is shown unedited except that local file paths are replaced by <project>. The numbers match those in Sections 3 to 7.

Output of: environment check

```
Python 3.11.15
pandas 3.0.2
numpy 2.4.4
sklearn 1.8.0
scipy 1.17.1
```

Output of: python3 src/data_prep.py

```
INFO: Loading raw data from <project>/data/housing.csv
INFO: Loaded 20640 rows and 10 columns
INFO: Missing values by column:
total_bedrooms    207
INFO: Removed 0 duplicate rows
INFO: Removed 0 invalid/non-physical rows
INFO: Removed 965 top-coded records at/above $500001
INFO: Removed 1100 outlier rows based on IQR rule for ['rooms_per_household', 'population_per_household']
INFO: Final cleaned shape: 18575 rows, 13 columns
INFO: Saved cleaned data to <project>/data/housing_clean.csv
```

Output of: python3 src/eda.py

```
INFO: Loaded cleaned data: 18575 rows, 13 columns
INFO: Summary statistics:
                           count       mean       std       min        25%        50%        75%        max  skew
median_house_value       18575.0  193935.08  97841.88  14999.00  117100.00  176400.00  250900.00  500000.00  0.78
median_income            18575.0       3.69      1.54      0.50       2.55       3.48       4.61      13.15  0.80
housing_median_age       18575.0      28.53     12.49      1.00      18.00      29.00      37.00      52.00  0.07
rooms_per_household      18575.0       5.21      1.10      2.08       4.44       5.19       5.94       8.30  0.12
bedrooms_per_room        18575.0       0.21      0.06      0.04       0.18       0.20       0.24       1.00  2.49
population_per_household 18575.0       2.87      0.63      1.16       2.44       2.82       3.25       4.59  0.35
INFO: Saved all EDA figures to figures
```

Output of: python3 src/model.py

```
INFO: Loaded data for modeling: 18575 rows
INFO: Train size: 14860, Test size: 3715
INFO: Cross-validating linear_regression ...
INFO: linear_regression -> {'cv_rmse_mean': 57477.80084024812, 'cv_rmse_std': 1208.1145641161102, 'cv_rmse_folds':
    [57036.34929080748, 56203.2496761964, 56754.42955725143, 58187.45632015736, 59207.51935682797], 'rmse':
    58464.119739235415, 'mae': 43136.71415892046, 'r2': 0.6515927047554535, 'train_rmse': 57433.13815154557,
'train_mae':
    42646.60470833941, 'train_r2': 0.6532291965826214}
INFO: Cross-validating random_forest ...
INFO: random_forest -> {'cv_rmse_mean': 45203.5992903974, 'cv_rmse_std': 1391.495015087088, 'cv_rmse_folds':
    [44876.67846799184, 43565.04149295588, 45122.723864986394, 45032.42264792914, 47421.12997812373], 'rmse':
    44715.158571241605, 'mae': 29899.237387539808, 'r2': 0.796193533159184, 'train_rmse': 24831.74643006597,
'train_mae':
    15994.539378451145, 'train_r2': 0.9351765769423134}
INFO: Selected final model: random_forest
INFO: Saved model and metrics summary to <project>/models and <project>/reports
INFO: Top features:
                 feature  importance
           median_income    0.428546
  ocean_proximity_INLAND    0.180714
population_per_household    0.111351
               longitude    0.077372
                latitude    0.069072
      housing_median_age    0.041780
     rooms_per_household    0.024787
       bedrooms_per_room    0.022412
             total_rooms    0.010836
              population    0.009878
```

Output of: python3 src/rigor.py

```
TRAIN vs TEST {
 "linear": {
  "train_rmse": 57433.13815154557,
  "test_rmse": 58464.119739235415,
  "train_r2": 0.6532291965826214,
  "test_r2": 0.6515927047554535,
  "train_mae": 42646.60470833941,
  "test_mae": 43136.71415892046
 },
 "forest": {
```

```
  "train_rmse": 24831.746430065967,
  "test_rmse": 44715.158571241605,
  "train_r2": 0.9351765769423134,
  "test_r2": 0.796193533159184,
  "train_mae": 15994.539378451145,
  "test_mae": 29899.237387539808
 }
}
PAIRED FOLDS
  fold  lr_rmse  rf_rmse    diff
    1  57036.0  44877.0 12160.0
    2  56203.0  43565.0 12638.0
    3  56754.0  45123.0 11632.0
    4  58187.0  45032.0 13155.0
    5  59208.0  47421.0 11786.0
mean diff 12274  sd 627  95% CI (11496, 13053)  t=43.78 p=1.628e-06
BOOTSTRAP 95% CI RF test: RMSE [42752.92847772888, 46809.21732547043] R2 [0.7784668719185027, 0.8117285554015089] MAE
    [28820.516804447503, 31018.86124838968]
VIF {
 "households": 92.85565163189489,
 "total_bedrooms": 65.9309291898919,
 "population": 26.14733758296487,
 "total_rooms": 23.898151440428013,
 "latitude": 10.210663845143738,
 "longitude": 9.66174873316559,
 "rooms_per_household": 5.929642391047449,
 "bedrooms_per_room": 4.222679159521616,
 "population_per_household": 3.069234611185472,
 "median_income": 2.535218101923161,
 "housing_median_age": 1.3069316780797693
}
LR COEF (numeric = per 1 SD)
 ocean_proximity_ISLAND        122803.0
median_income                   60845.0
latitude                       -57227.0
longitude                      -54938.0
ocean_proximity_INLAND         -51668.0
ocean_proximity_NEAR BAY       -30891.0
households                      27740.0
ocean_proximity_NEAR OCEAN     -22093.0
population_per_household       -22068.0
ocean_proximity_<1H OCEAN      -18151.0
PERMUTATION IMPORTANCE (RMSE increase, $)
 median_income               42430.0
latitude                    20576.0
ocean_proximity             19897.0
longitude                   19357.0
population_per_household    17601.0
housing_median_age           6562.0
rooms_per_household          1172.0
bedrooms_per_room             716.0
total_rooms                   294.0
total_bedrooms                250.0
households                    129.0
population                    111.0
ERROR BY VALUE BIN
                             n      rmse      mae  bias_mean_pred_minus_actual
bin
(0.0, 100000.0]          702.0   28077.0  17926.0                      15287.0
(100000.0, 200000.0]    1484.0   34988.0  23896.0                      13994.0
(200000.0, 300000.0]     967.0   42086.0  31622.0                       -325.0
(300000.0, 400000.0]     407.0   56191.0  42753.0                     -25724.0
(400000.0, 500000.0]     155.0  115286.0  97102.0                     -96630.0
ERROR BY OCEAN
                 n     rmse      mae  bias_mean_pred_minus_actual
ocean
<1H OCEAN   1622.0  45384.0  31858.0                       3142.0
INLAND      1195.0  34322.0  21200.0                       1903.0
NEAR BAY     417.0  52813.0  37184.0                       1968.0
NEAR OCEAN   481.0  56145.0  38592.0                      -5101.0
ISLAND rows in cleaned data: 5
SPATIAL CV  random 44347 ± 1393   spatial-block 59977 ± 7806
saved
```

Output of: python3 src/sensitivity.py

```
INFO: Loading raw data from <project>/data/housing.csv
INFO: Loaded 20640 rows and 10 columns
INFO: Removed 0 duplicate rows
INFO: Removed 0 invalid/non-physical rows
INFO: Removed 965 top-coded records at/above $500001
INFO: Removed 1100 outlier rows based on IQR rule for ['rooms_per_household', 'population_per_household']
INFO: Loading raw data from <project>/data/housing.csv
INFO: Loaded 20640 rows and 10 columns
INFO: Removed 0 duplicate rows
INFO: Removed 0 invalid/non-physical rows
INFO: Removed 965 top-coded records at/above $500001
INFO: Loading raw data from <project>/data/housing.csv
```

```
INFO: Loaded 20640 rows and 10 columns
INFO: Removed 0 duplicate rows
INFO: Removed 0 invalid/non-physical rows
INFO: Removed 1210 outlier rows based on IQR rule for ['rooms_per_household', 'population_per_household']
INFO: Loading raw data from <project>/data/housing.csv
INFO: Loaded 20640 rows and 10 columns
INFO: Removed 0 duplicate rows
INFO: Removed 0 invalid/non-physical rows
INFO: Removed 965 top-coded records at/above $500001
                                                variant  n_train  n_test   rf_rmse  rf_r2   lr_rmse  lr_r2
    rf_rmse_under500k  lr_rmse_under500k
                                 baseline (team pipeline)    14860    3715 44715.159  0.796 58464.120  0.652
                   NaN                NaN
                                   no IQR outlier removal    15740    3935 46362.574  0.784 62105.213  0.613
                   NaN                NaN
                                keep $500,001 capped rows    15544    3886 49500.614  0.819 64901.446  0.688
    44990.176          57384.901
leakage-free (split first; train-only medians & IQR bounds)    14868    3711 46331.803  0.785 59520.567  0.645
                   NaN                NaN
                         leakage-free, test keeps outliers    14868    3935 46388.562  0.784 62177.376  0.612
                   NaN                NaN
```

Output of: python3 src/hyperparam_check.py .

```
team (150 trees, depth 18, leaf 3): RMSE 44,715  R2 0.796  size 52.1 MB
larger (300 trees, unconstrained): RMSE 44,520  R2 0.798  size 402.3 MB
```